

Spain Family Trip — Barcelona → Madrid

Dates: Wednesday, July 8 → Tuesday, July 14, 2026 (7 days / 6 nights)

Travelers: 4 — Mom & Dad (74), you & your brother (29)

Route: Land Barcelona 9:00 AM Jul 8 → 3 nights Barcelona → AVE train Sat Jul 11 → 3 nights Madrid → fly to NY/NJ Tue Jul 14

Planning notes for a multigenerational trip: central hotels chosen for shortest distances to your actual wishlist, gentle pacing for your parents, timed morning tickets to beat the July heat (highs ~30–36°C / 86–97°F), taxis over long walks, and afternoon rest gaps before the late Spanish dinners.

BOOK TODAY — the trip starts in 3 days

These sell out or get expensive fastest. Book in this order, today:

Priori	What	Slot to book	Price (pp)	Where
1	**Sagrada Família** — Thu Jul 9	**9:00 AM** entry (Quiet Hour)	€26 adult / €21 senior; towers +€10 (sons only)	sagradafamilia.org/en/tickets-individuals
2	**Train BCN→Madrid** — Sat Jul 11	**AVE 03080, 8:25 AM** (nonstop)	~€60–110 Standard, ~€90–140 Confort/Premium	renfe.com
3	**Stays**: "Luxury Modernist Apartment" (BCN, Airbnb) + Gran View (MAD)	Jul 8–11 / Jul 11–14	~\$635/nt BCN · 2-BR unit MAD	airbnb.com (verify HUTB license!) / granviewapartments.com
4	**Spotify Camp Nou Experience** — Fri Jul 10	**9:30 AM** guided session (English)	from €69	fcbarcelona.com/en/tickets/camp-nou-experience
5	**Bernabéu Tour** — Mon Jul 13	**9:00 AM** opening (or €44 Flexible-time)	€37 online	realmadrid.com/en-US/tour-bernabeu
6	**Royal Palace** — Sun Jul 12	~10:00 AM timed entry	see site	entradas.patrimonionacional.es
7	**Tuk-tuk tour Madrid** — Sat Jul 11	~6:30 PM, private, 1.5–2 hr	varies	book a rated operator online in advance
8	**Casa Batlló (interior)** — Thu Jul 9	~5:00 PM timed entry	from ~€29 (senior discount)	casabatllo.es
9	**Park Güell** — Fri Jul 10	~6:30 PM golden hour	~€10–18 (check site)	parkguell.barcelona
10	**Flamenco tablao** — Sun Jul 12	early show (~7 PM — confirm times)	~€50–65 with drink	Corral de la Morería (corraldelamoreria.com)
11	**Reina Sofía (Guernica)** — Mon Jul 13	~4:00 PM (open Mondays)	~€12	museoreinasofia.es

- Sagrada tickets are **nominative — names must match photo ID**, and July 2026 is centenary-year peak season: morning slots genuinely can sell out days ahead. If the 9:00–10:00 window for Jul 9 is gone, take anything before 11:00, or check Tiqets (authorized reseller with separate allotments), or book the guided-tour ticket (sells out slowest). ⚠️ *A teachers'-strike protest was intermittently restricting basilica access as of July 5 — re-check sagradafamilia.org the morning of your visit.*

- Restaurants: **Botín, Casa Lucio, 7 Portes** — call/book online today too. The ultra-fine-dining rooms (Disfrutar, DiverXO) are realistically gone at 3 days' notice, but cancellations happen — try their sites; **StreetXO** takes walk-ins.

At a Glance

Day	Date	Base	Highlights
1	Wed Jul 8	Barcelona	Land 9:00 AM, settle in, Gothic Quarter + La Boqueria + beach sunset
2	Thu Jul 9	Barcelona	**Sagrada Família 9:00 AM (reserved)**, beach/pool, **Casa Batlló interior 5 PM**
3	Fri Jul 10	Barcelona	**Camp Nou tour 9:30 AM**, beach afternoon, **Park Güell golden hour**
4	Sat Jul 11	→ Madrid	**AVE 8:25→11:27**, lunch at Sol, evening tuk-tuk tour + Plaza Mayor
5	Sun Jul 12	Madrid	Royal Palace, **Mercado de San Miguel**, shopping, **flamenco show**, La Latina
6	Mon Jul 13	Madrid	**Bernabéu tour 9:00 AM**, **Guernica at Reina Sofía**, San Ginés finale
7	Tue Jul 14	→ NY/NJ	Midday nonstop from Madrid-Barajas

Where to Stay — chosen by distance to YOUR list

Barcelona (3 nights: Jul 8-11)

Your Barcelona list = Sagrada Família, Camp Nou, beach, old town, and the train station. I mapped both candidate hotels against every stop:

Destination	Pg. de Gràcia base (Suites Avenue / Majestic)	Hotel Arts (beachfront)
Sagrada Família	**8-10 min taxi / 23 min flat walk**	10-15 min taxi
Gothic Quarter	**~24 min flat walk / 8 min taxi**	8-12 min taxi
Barceloneta beach	10-15 min taxi	**on the sand (0 min)**
Park Güell	**11-15 min taxi**	15-25 min taxi
Camp Nou	**10-15 min taxi**	16-25 min taxi
Sants station (train day)	**7-12 min taxi / 12 min metro L3**	12-20 min taxi

Chosen stay — "Luxury Modernist Apartment in the Core of the City" (Airbnb).

3 bedrooms / 2 baths, **4.96 rating over 450 stays** — as bulletproof as Airbnb gets — in a restored modernista building in central Eixample, ~\$635/night total for all four (well under two 5★ rooms). Everyone gets their own bedroom and the two baths solve the 8:40 AM Sagrada departure.

Verify on the listing before paying (60 seconds): ① HUTB license number

displayed — no number, no booking; ② **elevator** confirmed; ③ **A/C in the bedrooms**; ④ **map pin between Plaça de Catalunya and Diagonal, near the Passeig de**

Gràcia axis; ⑤ message the host about **9 AM Wed bag-drop** before booking.

Write the exact address on the day sheet once Airbnb reveals it.

Fallback chain if it fails a check or gets booked: ① **Designer Duplex in the City Center (Airbnb, 2BR/2BA, 4.86 × 197, ~\$418/nt — confirm the parents' bedroom**

is on the lower level); ② quote two rooms at **Sir Victor / NH Collection Calderón / Condes de Barcelona**; ③ Suites Avenue **serviced apartments (Pg. de Gràcia 83, ☎ +34 934 874 159)** — the always-solid baseline. Splurge: **Majestic (5★)**; beach-first: **Hotel Arts (5★)**.

Madrid (3 nights: Jul 11-14)

Chosen stay — Gran View Apartments (serviced apartments, Gran Vía 48).

Best value with everything still at your feet — it's *on Gran Vía itself* at Callao, which actually puts the shopping and Royal Palace **closer** than the Four Seasons:

Destination	From Gran View (Gran Vía 48)
Zara flagship (Gran Vía 34)	**3 min walk**
Bershka (Gran Vía 25)	**4 min walk**
Chocolatería San Ginés	**7 min walk**
Puerta del Sol	**8 min walk**
Plaza Mayor	**11 min walk**
Royal Palace	**12 min walk**
Mercado de San Miguel	**13 min walk**
Santiago Bernabéu	10-18 min taxi (~€10-15 for all 4)
Atocha station	8-12 min taxi (~€9-11)

1-bedroom units sleep 4, or take a **2-bedroom apartment**; the building has a **pool + solarium, gym, and A/C**. Gran Vía 48 · ☎ +34 91 598 14 09 · book at granviewapartments.com. *Confirm the lift and early bag-drop are arranged for Saturday's 11:45 AM arrival — you'll likely drop bags and lunch first anyway.*

Splurge alternative — Four Seasons Hotel Madrid (5★, Calle de Sevilla 3) — the plan's original pick, equally central (Sol 5 min), with full hotel service and spa.

(Also solid: Thompson Madrid, NH Collection Suecia, Eric Vökel Madrid Suites.)

Booking tip for both cities: a true 2-bedroom unit (not two separate apartments), lift confirmed explicitly, A/C in every room, and a step-free bathroom for your parents.

Train — Barcelona → Madrid, Saturday July 11 (verified timetable)

Important 2026 reality check: Adif track works add ~25-30 min to *every* train on this line until ~December 2026 — so trips take **3 h+**, **not the advertised 2 h 30**, frequencies are reduced, and fares are high. Verified departures from Renfe's official data for **Saturday, July 11, 2026** (all arrive **Madrid-Puerta de Atocha**):

Train	Departs Sants	Arrives Atocha	Duration	Stops
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Renfe AVE 03062	5:50	9:40	3h50	5
Renfe AVE 03302	6:35	9:52	3h17	1
Ouigo (budget)	7:35	11:05	3h30	1
Renfe AVE 03082	8:00	11:44	3h44	4
Renfe AVE 03080	**8:25**	**11:27**	**3h02**	**nonstop**
Renfe AVE 03092	9:00	12:24	3h24	2
Renfe AVE 03304	9:55	13:44	3h49	5

Book the 8:25 AVE 03080 — the only nonstop and the fastest morning train, at a civilized hour for your parents, landing you in Madrid at 11:27 with the whole afternoon and evening ahead. If you want to arrive even earlier, the **6:35 (arr. 9:52) is the early-bird option**. In Elige Confort or Premium **you get wide 2+1** seats, at-seat meal service, and Renfe's free **Atendo** assistance for your parents (request it when booking — they'll help with luggage and boarding at both stations).
 Notes: iryo's morning times couldn't be verified (its old 8:45 no longer runs — check iryo.eu directly); Ouigo is cheapest but charges for luggage beyond one cabin bag + one carry-on each. Availability is live-only — book on renfe.com today.

✈ Flight home — Madrid → NY/NJ, Tuesday July 14 (nonstop options)

Flight	Departs MAD	Arrives	Airport	Barajas terminal
United UA50	10:50	13:15	Newark (EWR)	T1
American AA95	10:25	12:30	JFK	T4
Iberia IB211	~12:30	14:55	JFK	T4 (boards T4S)
Delta DL127	12:45	~15:00	JFK	T1
Iberia IB325	16:20	~18:00	JFK	T4 — lands into evening rush

If you haven't booked yet, the **midday Iberia IB211 or Delta DL127** fit your parents best: taxi from the hotel **~8:15-8:30 AM** (fixed **€33 flat fare** to the airport, ~30-45 min), airport by 9:00 (Iberia recommends up to 4 h for US-bound security), and a mid-afternoon landing in New York. Iberia/American board from the **T4S satellite** — budget an extra 30-45 min for the airside train + passport control. *Air Europa's Tuesday service couldn't be confirmed — avoid unless verified.*
 If your flight is already booked, just apply the same timeline: **leave the hotel** ~4 hours before departure.

Day-by-Day

Day 1 — Wed Jul 8 · Land in Barcelona (9:00 AM)

- **9:00 AM:** land at BCN; taxi to the apartment (~25-35 min, ~€35-40). The unit likely won't be ready — arrange bag-drop/early check-in with the host in advance;

otherwise leave bags and have a slow coffee/brunch nearby.

- **Afternoon:** nap/pool — everyone will be jet-lagged; protect this rest window.
- **Evening:** gentle **Gothic Quarter + La Rambla** stroll while it cools — duck into **La Boqueria market** on the way (stalls close ~8 PM) for ten minutes of the famous food stalls and a fresh-juice stop — then an early tapas dinner. If energy allows, finish with a **sunset drink at a beach chiringuito** on Barceloneta.

Early night — tomorrow has a 9:00 reservation.

Day 2 — Thu Jul 9 · Sagrada Família (reserved) + Beach

- **8:40 AM:** arrive at the basilica for security (15 min early). **9:00 AM entry** — the "Quiet Hour" slot: **thinnest crowds of the day, morning sun through the blue Nativity-façade glass, and cool air.** Parents use step-free **Entrance B (Carrer de la Marina)** — **lifts throughout, free loaner wheelchairs if wanted.**
- **Towers:** you and your brother can add tower access (+€10) — but Mom & Dad should skip it: the descent is 300–500 narrow spiral stairs on foot, no lift down.
- **Late morning:** stroll/taxi back via **Passeig de Gràcia** — La Pedrera façade on the way (directly across the street from Suites Avenue).
- **Afternoon: beach + pool** heat break — swim at Barceloneta or laze at the rooftop.
- **5:00 PM: Casa Batlló — inside this time** (timed entry, ~90 min). Gaudí's dragon-spine house a 7-minute stroll down Passeig de Gràcia: the blue-tiled light well and whale-rib attic are the best interior in Barcelona. Air-conditioned with lifts — the ideal late-afternoon slot for your parents.
- **Evening:** dinner in the Eixample or El Born; optional **sunset harbor cruise** from Port Vell (zero walking, great for the parents).

Day 3 — Fri Jul 10 · FC Barcelona's Camp Nou + Beach

- **9:15 AM:** taxi to **Spotify Camp Nou, Access 15 (C/ Arístides Maillol)** — arrive 15 min before the **9:30 guided Experience session** (latecomers get downgraded to museum-only). ~2 h: museum + trophy gallery + Messi Zone, immersive 360° room, panoramic view of the rebuilt bowl, and guided access into the first-tier stands. Note for Mom & Dad: everything is step-free with lifts **up to** the panoramic viewpoint; **the final descent into the stands is stairs-only — they** can wait at the viewpoint while you two go down. (Renovation continues: no dressing rooms/pitch walk on the standard route yet.)
- **Lunch + afternoon:** back east for a **final beach afternoon** — Barceloneta or the quieter Nova Icària stretch.
- **6:30 PM: Park Güell — now a committed stop** (timed tickets sell out like the Sagrada's; book today). Taxi to the **upper entrance** so nobody climbs the hill; golden hour gives the coolest air and prettiest light on the mosaic terrace. If the parents are out of energy by Friday evening, you two go alone while they rest — the **Montjuïc cable car** is their low-effort alternative.

- **Night:** seafood/paella farewell dinner (7 Portes or Can Majó). Pack for the train.

Day 4 — Sat Jul 11 · AVE to Madrid + Old-Madrid Evening

- **7:40 AM:** taxi to **Barcelona-Sants** (10–15 min; Atendo assistance meets you if requested).
 - **8:25 AM: AVE 03080 nonstop → Madrid-Atocha 11:27.**
 - **11:45 AM:** taxi to Gran View Apartments, Gran Vía 48 (8–12 min); drop bags, lunch around **Callao/Puerta del Sol** (8-min walk — you're staying on top of it).
 - **Afternoon:** siesta — travel day + tonight is busy.
 - **~6:30 PM: Tuk-tuk tour** (pre-booked, private, 1.5–2 h): yes, the touts by Plaza Mayor seem scammy — that's why you book a rated operator ahead — but the format is genuinely perfect here: a fun, zero-walking sweep of the Royal Palace exterior, cathedral, Plaza de Oriente, Gran Vía, and old town in the golden hour.
- Ask the operator to end the route at the Temple of Debod** — the real ancient Egyptian temple with Madrid's best sunset view, for zero extra effort.
- **Evening:** dinner under the arcades of **Plaza Mayor**.

Day 5 — Sun Jul 12 · Royal Palace, San Miguel & Shopping

- **10:00 AM: Royal Palace** (timed tickets; lifts available) + **Plaza de Oriente**.
- **~12:30 PM:** flat 10-min walk to **Mercado de San Miguel** — your must-do. Graze long and slow: jamón, croquetas, oysters, vermouth. Arriving before ~1 PM beats the worst crush.
- **Afternoon:** siesta.
- **~5:00 PM: Puerta del Sol** (Km 0 plaque, the bear-and-strawberry-tree statue), then **Bershka (Gran Vía 25)** and the **Zara flagship (Gran Vía 34)** — 3–4 min walks from your apartment. Fold in the **Spanish McDonald's** stop here for the menu comparison the four of you can argue about at dinner.
- **~7:00 PM: Flamenco at a top tablao** — seated, air-conditioned, and one of Spain's great live experiences; take the **early show** so the night stays easy for your parents. First choice **Corral de la Morería** (Calle Morería 17, near the Royal Palace — the world's most famous tablao); **Torres Bermejas** near Gran Vía is the closer-to-the-hotel backup. Book today and confirm exact showtimes.
- **~9:15 PM:** short taxi to **La Latina** — Sunday is its big tapas night (Cava Baja) — for a late-but-light bite, or Casa Lucio if you snagged a table.

Day 6 — Mon Jul 13 · Real Madrid's Bernabéu + Sweet Finale

- **8:45 AM:** taxi up the Castellana (~15 min, one cab fits all four, ~€10–15).
- 9:00 AM Bernabéu tour at opening** — museum with all 15 European Cups, the renovated bowl with its wraparound 360° screen, changing rooms and dugout. ~2 h. Heads-up: the route includes **numerous stretches of stairs** — if either parent would struggle, the €44 Flexible ticket plus the club's lift-served partial route (contact them ahead) is the safer setup.

- **Lunch + siesta.**
- **~4:00 PM: Reina Sofía for *Guernica***** — Picasso's masterpiece is arguably Spain's most important artwork, the museum is **open Mondays** (it closes Tuesdays), fully accessible, and this is a one-hour in-and-out visit: Guernica, the rooms around it, done. Gentler alternatives if the family prefers: **Retiro Park** (flat, shady, rowboats) or the **Prado** (benches throughout).
- **Evening:** farewell dinner — **Sobrino de Botín** (world's oldest restaurant, 1725; book now) — then **Chocolatería San Ginés** for the churros-and-thick-chocolate finale, 7 min from the apartment. Pack tonight.

Day 7 — Tue Jul 14 · Fly home to NY/NJ

- **~8:15 AM:** taxi to Barajas (€33 flat fare, 30–45 min) for a midday nonstop — airport ~4 h ahead per Iberia's US-bound guidance (T4S flyers: extra 30–45 min).
- Land New York mid-afternoon. ¡Buen viaje!

Your Wishlist — all covered

- ☑ **Mercado de San Miguel** — Day 5, long grazing lunch
- ☑ **Tuk-tuk tour** (reputable, pre-booked) — Day 4 evening
- ☑ **Royal Palace** — Day 5 · **Plaza Mayor** — Day 4 evening · **Puerta del Sol** — Days 4–6
- ☑ **Sagrada Família basilica** — reserved 9:00 AM slot, Thu Jul 9
- ☑ **Camp Nou (FC Barcelona)** — Day 3, 9:30 AM Experience
- ☑ **Santiago Bernabéu (Real Madrid)** — Day 6, 9:00 AM tour
- ☑ **Beach time** — Days 1, 2 & 3
- ☑ **Zara flagship + Bershka** — Day 5 (8–10 min walk from hotel)
- ☑ **Spanish McDonald's** — Day 5 · **San Ginés** — Day 6 finale

Don't-miss additions folded in:

- ☑ **La Boqueria market** — Day 1 evening stroll
- ☑ **Casa Batlló interior** — Day 2, 5:00 PM
- ☑ **Park Güell** — Day 3, 6:30 PM golden hour (committed — book today)
- ☑ **Flamenco tablao** — Day 5, ~7:00 PM early show
- ☑ **Guernica (Reina Sofía)** — Day 6, ~4:00 PM (open Mondays)

Top-Tier Restaurant Picks

With 3 days to go: **book the classics today by phone/web**; treat the 3-star rooms as lottery tickets (check for cancellations). First sitting ~8 PM suits your parents best.

Barcelona

- **Splurge: Disfrutar** (3★ Michelin, ranked world's #1 — cancellations only at this notice), **Lasarte** (3★), or the warmer **Cinc Sentits** (1★).
- **Iconic & family-friendly: 7 Portes** (paella institution, est. 1836), **Els Quatre Gats** (Picasso's haunt), **Can Majó** (beachside paella).
- **Tapas:** Cal Pep, El Xampanyet, Quimet & Quimet — go at opening for seats.

Madrid

- **Splurge: DiverXO** (3★, Spain's hardest table — cancellation-watch only), **DSTAgE** (2★), or walk-in-friendly **StreetXO**.
 - **Iconic & family-friendly: Sobrino de Botín** (oldest restaurant on Earth, 1725 — wood-oven suckling pig, steps from Plaza Mayor), **Casa Lucio** (huevos rotos), **Taberna La Bola** (cocido madrileño).
 - **Tapas:** San Miguel market grazing + Cava Baja crawl in La Latina (Sunday!).
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Comfort & Pacing (traveling with parents at 74)

- **Heat plan:** all big sights are booked at 9:00–9:30 AM starts; afternoons are pool/siesta; evenings are for squares, shopping, and dinners.
 - **Taxis liberally:** every leg above is one cheap cab; a standard taxi seats all 4.
 - **Renfe Atendo:** free assistance at both stations — request with the ticket.
 - **Stairs watch:** Sagrada towers (skip for parents), Camp Nou stands descent (viewpoint wait), Bernabéu route (contact club if concerned). Everything else is step-free or lift-served.
 - **Dining:** first sitting ~8 PM, or big lunch + light tapas night.
 - **Pharmacies** (green cross) everywhere; carry meds in original packaging + a list of generic names; confirm travel insurance covers all four.
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Sources

- Renfe official GTFS timetable feed (service date 2026-07-11) — [renfe.com](https://www.renfe.com) — <https://www.renfe.com> · Ouigo timetables — <https://www.ouigo.com/es/horarios-trenes-ouigo> · [Seat61 Barcelona-Madrid](https://www.seat61.com/trains-and-routes/barcelona-to-madrid-by-train.htm) — <https://www.seat61.com/trains-and-routes/barcelona-to-madrid-by-train.htm>
- Sagrada Família — official tickets — <https://sagradafamilia.org/en/tickets-individuals> · hours & access — <https://sagradafamilia.org/en/schedules-how-to-get>
- FC Barcelona — Camp Nou Experience — <https://www.fcbarcelona.com/en/tickets/camp-nou-experience> · [tours-are-back announcement](https://www.fcbarcelona.com/en/club/news/4440096/spotify-camp-nou-tours-are-back) — <https://www.fcbarcelona.com/en/club/news/4440096/spotify-camp-nou-tours-are-back>
- Real Madrid — Bernabéu Tour — <https://www.realmadrid.com/en-US/tour-bernabeu/individual>
- Iberia US-bound arrival guidance — <https://www.iberia.com/us/time-limit/> · Madrid airport taxi flat fare — <https://www.madrid-traveller.com/madrid-airport-to-the-city-center/> · MAD-JFK nonstops — <https://www.flightconnections.com/flights-from-mad-to-jfk>
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